

OSU SCHOOL OF ENTREPRENEURSHIP · RIATA CENTER · SEPTEMBER 24, 2026

Business in the Age of AI

How AI actually shows up inside a small business, from the people I work with every week in Stillwater.



Logan Shimmer
Shimmer Labs · Stillwater

shimmerlabs.co

What we'll **cover.**

- 1 Who I am and how I work with local businesses
- 2 The one question every project starts with
- 3 How a process becomes an automation
- 4 Real examples from businesses in this town
- 5 What I **won't** automate, and why
- 6 Tools worth learning, and tools I'd skip
- 7 **Your questions**

Hi, I'm **Logan Shimmer**.



2009 **OSU grad**, mechanical engineering.

Then Moved to **Silicon Valley** to work in tech, using AI the whole way:

- **Manufacturing:** AI inspecting widgets on the line for quality.
- **Marketing:** the right message, to the right person, at the right time.
- **The power grid:** cutting home energy costs, absorbing electric cars.

2025 **Moved home to Stillwater.** Family's all here.

Now Started **Shimmer Labs**, the Sherpa for local businesses figuring out AI.

I help local businesses **modernize their processes.**

Sometimes with AI, when it fits.

CLIENTS

Owners who hire me

- An **HVAC company** drowning in vendor invoices
- An **auto shop** with a phone that never stops
- A **tree service** that quotes from the truck
- A **yoga studio** re-signing 200 students twice a year

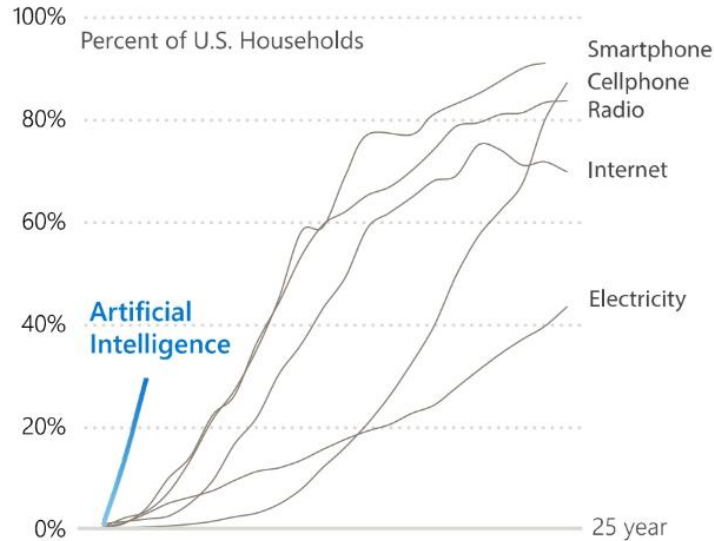
HOW IT WORKS

Business Operations Consulting

- 1 **"What's eating your week?"** Free. A one-page snapshot: the five tasks and the first move.
- 2 **Assessment.** A day in the business. Process maps, an hours ledger, a written 90-day plan.
- 3 **Audit, optimize, automate.** In that order. Most 15-step processes only need nine.
- 4 **Build it with them, on their screen.** AI only where it earns its place.

Everything on the next slides **happened to a business in this town.**

AI hit like a ton of bricks.



Adoption vs. past technologies, % of U.S. households. Source: Microsoft AI Diffusion Report, 2025.

2 months

for ChatGPT to reach 100 million users. **The fastest-adopted technology in human history.**

1 billion+

use ChatGPT **every week**. That's one tool. Add Gemini, Copilot, Meta AI, and it's **billions** more.

OpenAI, Google, Meta, 2026

Pandora's box is open. **And nobody handed us the owner's manual.**

Hands up: **who used AI this week?**

Now think about the last thing you asked it to do.

Did it sound a lot like what you'd have Googled a couple years ago?

(And if you use the grammar fixer in your email... **that's AI too.**)

5%

of companies that piloted Microsoft's Copilot ever scaled it. **Most people are stuck using AI like a fancy Google.** If that's you... you're not alone.

Gartner, 2025 M365 & Copilot Survey

THE PROBLEM

You're Using a **Ferrari** as a Go-Kart



WHAT MOST PEOPLE DO

Open ChatGPT. Ask a question. Close the tab.

That's like hiring a full-time employee and only asking them to Google things.



WHAT'S ACTUALLY POSSIBLE

**A software agent that works for you 24/7.
No prompting required.**

Monitors your business, drafts outreach, flags problems before you wake up.

The answer isn't a better tool. **It's a better system.**

The Procrastination Problem

”

*What could you use AI for? It's always the same answer — **the procrastination things. The tasks you really wait and put off.** When you use it for that type of repetitive work, you actually reinvest the time in things that give you energy.*

— Julie Bedard, BCG Henderson Institute
Harvard Business Review, March 2026

15%

Burnout **drops** when you use these tools for **repetitive tasks**

BCG, 1,488 workers surveyed

33%

Decision fatigue **increases** when you juggle 4+ tools with no plan

BCG Henderson Institute, HBR 2026

39%

More **major errors** from unsupported tool overload

BCG Henderson Institute, HBR 2026

The right tasks + the right system = **less stress, not more.**

“What do you **dread** doing most at work?”

That's the whole intake. I stand next to them, they talk, I write it all down. **Nobody says “I need AI.”** They say “I hate Mondays because of the invoices.”

The dread list **is** the roadmap.

Start where you **groan**.

"Oh god... the schedule. I have to do the schedule."

...wait. Can we do that one next?

— a local owner, two automations later

1,500

workers studied by **Harvard Business Review**.
The ones who got the most out of AI, and burned out the least, pointed it at the work they **put off the most**.

Not the fancy, creative work.
The tedious stuff you dread.

The eye-roll is the litmus test. **Whatever makes you groan... that's your first automation.**

Three questions. **Then I build.**

1

What do you dread?

They talk, I write. Every task, every annoyance, no filtering.

Ten minutes, usually a page and a half.

"What else?"

2

What does the process look like?

Pick the worst one. Walk it step by step on a whiteboard.

Where does it start, where does it end, who touches it.

"Then what happens?"

3

What tech does each step touch?

Email, QuickBooks, a spreadsheet, a text thread, a PDF in a folder. **That list is the architecture.** Now I know what to wire together.

"Where does that live?"

Map the dread, list the tools, **and the automation designs itself.**

**Here's how local Stillwater
businesses have streamlined their
operations.**

Twice a year, the students leave. **The paperwork doesn't.**



Sweat Yoga & Fitness · Stillwater

Every semester break: a **tidal wave of cancellations and freezes.**

It all lands in the **same two weeks**, right when the owner has the least time for it.

Now she gets a **daily digest**. No more approving each one. It's run flawlessly for months.



A member emails: cancel, or freeze till August?



The contract goes out for her member to sign



AI reads the signed doc and updates her booking system



The owner gets one daily digest. That's it.

What she got back: **dinner with her daughter, uninterrupted.**

Every one of these is the **same shape**.



Tools change (n8n, Zapier, Make, whatever is cheapest that month). **The shape doesn't.** If you can draw the four boxes for your dread task, it can be built.

Trigger → read → do → **human checks**. That last box is not optional.

Under the hood: a **large language model**.

Today's AI is a **large language model**. It trained on a mountain of writing, so it's great at three things:

READS

the member's request in her inbox **and the signed paperwork they send back:** cancel date, freeze length

WRITES

the reply **in her voice**, and fills out the contract

UNDERSTANDS

her policy, what a real signature looks like, which buttons to click, **and when to flag her for help**

Is a job mostly **read, understand, or write**? Then it's probably automatable.

Ten hours in the sun. Then two more at the keyboard.

READS

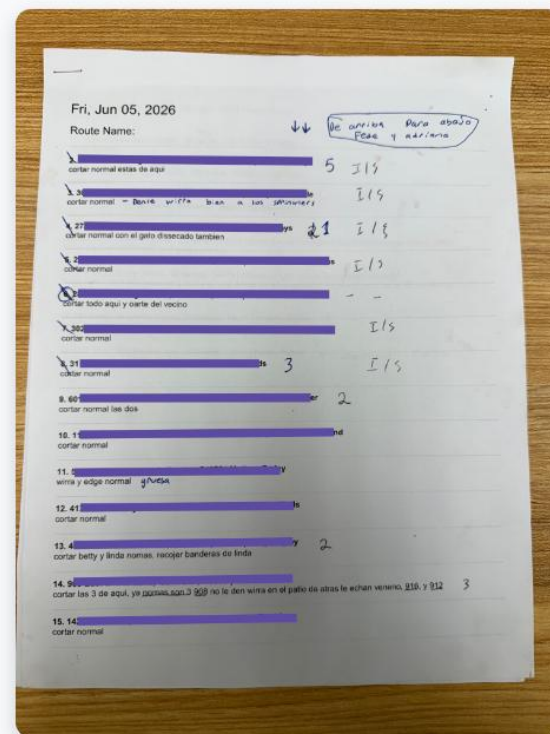
the job list, **printed and handwritten, even in Spanish**

UNDERSTANDS

what extra work needs an invoice, and what job **got skipped and needs rescheduling**

WRITES

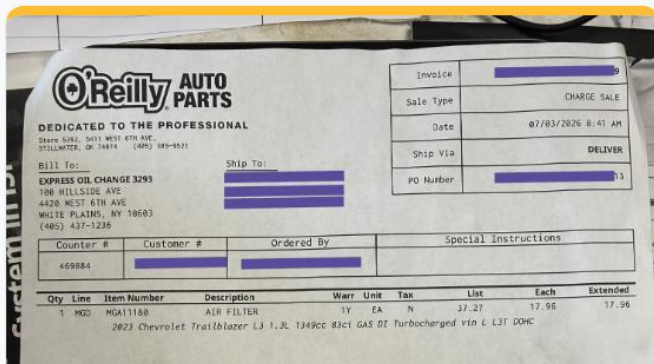
all of it **into his customer database**



Two hours of typing became **one photo.**

A few more, quick.

Other things I've seen local businesses hand off:



Expenses

Snap a receipt and it's logged, **then sent to the bookkeeping software or the accountant.**



Social comments

Answer the ones that matter, **skip the trolls**, without getting dragged to their level.



Prospecting

Snap a yard sign or work truck around town → **into the CRM for tomorrow's call list.**

Three Businesses, Three Wins

The Bookkeeper

Invoice reconciliation: 6 hrs/wk → 45 min

Saved \$15K/yr

The Realtor

Lead follow-up: 2 days late → same-day

3 extra closings in Q1

The Contractor

Change orders: paper to automated alerts

Caught \$12K billing error

None of these businesses are tech companies. They just found the **right task**.

What This Looks Like for **Your** Business



Proposal Follow-Up

READ:

A lead fills out your contact form at 9pm.

UNDERSTAND:

They want a quote. They're comparing you to two other shops.

WRITE:

By 9:01 they have a response with your availability and a booking link.

No more leaving money on the table because your competitor responded first.



Sales Call Notes

READ:

You walk out of an on-site visit with a voice memo of the whole conversation.

UNDERSTAND:

Interprets the audio. Pulls out action items, follow-ups, and key decisions.

WRITE:

Notes written and CRM updated before you leave the parking lot.

No more logging touchpoints late into the evening.



Social Media Responses

READ:

Someone DMs your business page asking about pricing.

UNDERSTAND:

They want your rate card and availability for next week.

WRITE:

Sends your rate card and booking link. You find out when the appointment hits your calendar.

No more doom scrolling comments late at night when you could be with family.

These are **real use cases**. Not hypothetical.

Oklahoma's AI Innovators

Four companies building AI solutions right here in Oklahoma



1



Paycom

📍 Oklahoma City

HR Tech & Payroll AI. Generative AI for employee self-service, predictive workforce analytics. NYSE: PAYC.

2



Quillify

📍 Tulsa

Grant Writing AI. Helps businesses find and write grant applications using AI to simplify complex federal requirements.

3



Senslytics

📍 Oklahoma City

Causal AI for Energy. Predicts equipment failures with limited data by modeling cause-and-effect, not just correlations.

4



Meerir

📍 Oklahoma City

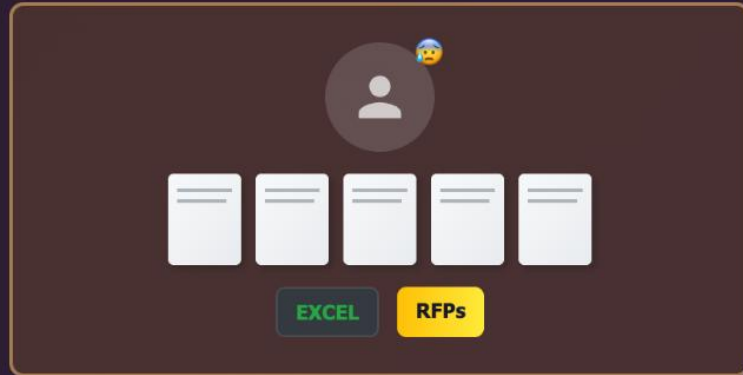
Aviation Intelligence. Agentic AI that gives plain-language access to radar, ADS-B, and drone data.

3 of these founders are featured in this course — hear directly from Oklahoma's AI practitioners.

Manual vs AI-Powered Grant Writing

How Quillify transforms grant finding and application writing

1 Manual Grant Search



20-40 hrs

Per grant application

2 The Gap

grants.gov
foundation.org
state-grants.gov
federal-RFPs...

1,000s

of active grants

Organizations pursue only 2-3/year. Money left on the table.

3 AI-Powered Grant Writing

Quillify Grant Assistant

12 matches

Found for you

Draft

Ready to review

Application 80% complete

80% less

time per application

1

Manual Grant Search

Grant seekers spend hours on grants.gov, foundation websites, and databases. Each application takes **20-40 hours** to write from scratch. Most fail—first-time success rate is ~20%.

2

The Scale Problem

There are **thousands of active grants** at any time. Organizations might qualify for dozens. But with limited staff, they can only pursue 2-3 per year. **Money left on the table.**

3

AI-Powered Grant Writing

Quillify scans grant databases, matches opportunities to your profile, generates first-draft applications. **80% less time per application.** Teams can pursue 5x more grants.

Three things I **won't** automate for you



Person-to-person conversations.

The text to a customer whose job went sideways. The reply to a bad review. The “are we still on for Tuesday.” **Your voice is the business. Keep it.**



The phone during business hours.

A bot answering after hours to triage is fine. **Say it's a bot in the first sentence.** Nine to five, a person picks up. People can hear the difference and they hold it against you.



Your social media images.

For the love of Pete. A blurry phone photo of your actual truck, your actual shop, your actual dog **beats a perfect AI image every single time right now.** Authentic and bad wins. People can tell.

Automate the paperwork. **Never the parts that make you you.**

CASE STUDY

The Klarna Story

2.3M

conversations/month

\$60M

saved annually

2 min

resolution (was 11 min)

853

roles automated

WHAT WENT WRONG

Customers got robotic, generic answers. No judgment calls. No empathy. Klarna became a laughingstock.

THE REAL PROBLEM

The agent was told to want **speed**. The business needed it to want **customer relationships**.

*Duolingo designed their AI to **teach, not just answer**. Completion up 15%, daily users up 51%.*

START HERE

Tools worth **learning now.**



Whiteboard and paper

Start here, always.

Map the process by hand. You can't skip the creativity part, and AI is bad at it.



n8n

Drag-and-drop automation. Free to self-host. **Most of what I build for clients runs here.**



Zapier

Same idea, easier start, costs more at scale. **Great first automation in an afternoon.**



Claude Code

Builds software from a conversation. **The glue between tools that don't talk to each other.**

OpenAI

Codex

OpenAI's version of the same. **Try both, keep the one that fits your brain.**

Paper first. Then the automation tool. **Then, and only then, the AI.**

Tools I'd **skip** for now.



End-to-end AI agents (OpenClaw, Hermes, and friends).

AI-only automations drift. Small errors compound. And models seem to get worse the day a newer one ships. **Build a harness and keep the AI isolated to the one step that deserves it.**



AI image and video for your marketing.

The backlash is already here. It's still in the uncanny valley. **Authentic and imperfect beats AI and overly polished, every time.**



Anything AI that says it'll get you rich quick.

Same scam, new hat. If the pitch is about the money instead of the work, close the tab.

The tool is never the business. **The customer is.**



Office hours, brought to you.

Twice a week I sit at WorkIT and answer whatever walks in. Today I brought that here. **Ask me anything about business operations or AI.**

AI Office Hours · Tue & Thu, 2–3 PM · WorkIT Stillwater, 901 S. Main
shimmerlabs.co · logan@shimmerlabs.co